

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Name the next action -> Who owns it -> By when -> Confirm aloud

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before ending any meeting or important conversation, name one specific next action with an owner and a date. Confirm it aloud.

BEST FOR

- Ending meetings with clear accountability
- Following up after important conversations
- Avoiding the ambiguity of 'we will follow up'
- Moving projects forward after a decision point

PHRASE BANK

Next-Step Close Phrases · Ending with clarity

- "Before we close — who is doing what and by when?"
- "Let us confirm the next action: [who] will do [what] by [when]."
- "The next step is X, and [Name] owns it by [date]."
- "To make this concrete: I will do X by Thursday."
- "Can we name the one thing that needs to happen before we next meet?"
- "Who is taking the first action from this conversation?"
- "I want to close with a clear next step — is that [X]?"

Confirmation Phrases · Getting explicit agreement

- "Does everyone agree that is the next step?"
- "Are you comfortable committing to that timeline?"
- "Any blockers to making that happen?"
- "Should I send a summary of that so it is in writing?"
- "Does that feel like a reasonable next step?"

Quick Closes · Fast lines for wrapping up

- "So — who does what by when?"
- "Next step?"
- "Who owns this one?"
- "What date shall we put on that?"
- "First action: mine or yours?"
- "What happens next, and who makes it happen?"

Pinning the Owner · When actions need a name against them

- "This needs one owner — who is it?"
- "I need a name against that action, not a 'we'."
- "A date, please — 'soon' has let us down before."
- "If nobody owns this by the end of the call, it will not happen."
- "I will take it — and I need your draft by Tuesday to do it."
- "Let us not leave until that has an owner and a deadline."

Warm Follow-Through · Making personal plans actually happen

- "I do not want this to become one of those 'we must catch up' promises — shall we pick a date now?"

- "Let us make it real: dinner, Thursday, ours?"
- "I loved this — can we book the next one before we forget?"
- "You mentioned needing help with the move — name a day and I am there."
- "Rather than 'sometime soon', how about Saturday?"
- "I will text you tomorrow to lock it in — that way we actually do it."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Ending with: 'Great chat — let us stay in touch'
Better: Let us follow up on this.
Best: The next step is X, [Name] owns it, deadline is Y. Sound right?
2. Weak: Vague action: 'Someone needs to look into that'
Better: That needs an owner.
Best: Specific owner, specific deliverable, specific date — confirmed by the owner in the room.
3. Weak: Meeting notes without confirmed commitments
Better: I will send around the notes afterwards.
Best: Confirm next steps aloud in the meeting before anyone leaves.

DECISION TREE

If A meeting is ending without clear next steps

Stop the conversation. Name the action before closing.

"Before we go — I want to be clear on who is doing what next."

If You are responsible for the next action

Name it aloud and commit to a timeline.

"I will have X done by Y. I will send you a note to confirm."

If The next action is unclear

Ask explicitly: 'What needs to happen next and who owns it?'

"I am not sure we have a clear next step — can we name one?"

If The next step is too large to be one action

Break it into the first concrete thing that needs to happen.

"The first step is X — everything else follows from that."

SCENARIOS

End of a project meeting with multiple attendees

Name each decision, owner, and deadline before closing. — "Three things before we close: X will do A by Monday, Y will do B by Wednesday, and we meet again on Friday."

One-on-one catch-up ending without clear follow-through

Name the one thing you each agreed to do. — "Let us make this concrete — I will do X and you will do Y by end of week."

Sales or negotiation call with ambiguous outcome

Name the next step and who initiates it. — "The next step from my side is X. What do you need to move forward from yours?"

Conversation that reached a decision but not a plan

Convert the decision into a first action. — "The decision is made — the first action is X. Who takes that?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In open exploratory conversations where closing too early cuts off valuable thinking.
- When the next step is not yet clear — forcing one prematurely creates false closure.
- In relationships where over-formalising the dynamic damages it (some close partnerships, personal relationships).

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Meeting audit

After your next meeting, write down: was there a clear next step? Who owns it? Was it confirmed?

Day 2 — Name one action

End one conversation today by naming one specific next action with an owner and a date.

Day 3 — First step only

When the next action is large, break it into the first concrete step.

Day 4 — Ask before closing

In one meeting, ask 'who is doing what and by when?' before the meeting ends.

Day 5 — Confirm aloud

After naming a next step, confirm it explicitly with the owner in the room.

Day 6 — Written confirmation

Send a short follow-up note after a key conversation confirming the next step.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did conversations result in clearer follow-through? Did any next steps fail to happen despite being named?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the next action before the conversation ended?
- Is there a clear owner for the next action?
- Is there a specific deadline?
- Was the next step confirmed aloud by the owner?
- Was the next step specific enough to actually be completed?
- Did I follow up in writing on important commitments?
- Did I avoid ending with vague language like 'let us stay in touch'?